

# Greek prose composition — a working manual

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A craft manual for composing Attic prose, organized by the decisions you make while writing: how to join this sentence to the last one, where the verb's weight falls, which mood the thought requires. It is built on the public-domain tradition — North & Hillard's *Greek Prose Composition for Schools* (1898) for graded drill, Auden's *Greek Prose Phrase-Book* (1899) for idiom, and Smyth's *Greek Grammar* (1920) as the court of appeal — with a handful of attributed debts to Eleanor Dickey's *An Introduction to the Composition and Analysis of Greek Prose* (Cambridge, 2016). Almost every rule below has exceptions; the references exist so you can find them.

Each section ends with pointers: **Drill** names North & Hillard (N&H) pages whose exercises practice the construction; **Lookup** names the fuller treatment.

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## 1. THE SKELETON — VERBS AND CONNECTIVES

The deepest structural fact about Greek prose, in Dickey's formulation: "A Greek sentence has a skeleton composed of verbs and connectives; most sentences, and indeed paragraphs, can be analyzed solely on the basis of such words." Everything else — nouns, adjectives, adverbs — is muscle hung on that skeleton. When you compose, build the skeleton first; when you revise, audit it first.

- **One verb-form per unit.** Every infinitive and participle opens its own unit of thought (attributive participles like ὁ κωλύων νόμος do not — they behave as adjectives). Each unit is either *coordinated* with its neighbor, which requires a conjunction, or *subordinated* to it — by conjunction, relative, participle, or infinitive. There is no third option; two finite verbs cannot simply sit side by side.
- **Nearly every sentence connects to its predecessor** with a small word near its front: δέ (and, but), καί (and), ἀλλά (but), γάρ (for), οὖν (therefore). English happily starts sentences cold; Greek does not, so when composing from English thought you must *add* connectives that the English never had. The habit runs so deep that Plato connects sentences even across a change of speaker in dialogue.
- **Punctuation is irrelevant to connection.** Classical Greek was written without it; a full stop between your sentences changes nothing about the need for a connective. Ask of every sentence: what word joins this to what came before?
- **μέν cannot connect backward.** It only looks forward to a coming δέ. A sentence opening with a μέν-phrase therefore still needs its own backward link — ἡ μὲν γὰρ βουλή..., where γάρ does the connecting and μέν does the forward-pointing.
- **The workhorses.** γάρ grounds what precedes (chains of γάρ are normal: state, ground, then ground the ground); οὖν resumes an argument or draws an inference; ἄρα marks the conclusion clinched; δέ is the colorless "next."
- **Licensed asyndeton** — connection omitted on purpose: when a sentence specifies or unpacks what a raised dot (·) announced; in answers to questions; and at moments of rhetorical height, where the abruptness itself is the effect.

**Drill:** N&H “Connection,” pp. 44–45; particles table, pp. 238–239. **Lookup:** Smyth on particles; Denniston, *The Greek Particles*, for the full doctrine.

μέν... δέ

Harder than it looks. Three conditions, all necessary:

1. The paired units must be **exactly grammatically parallel** — two finite clauses, or two participles, but never a participle paired against its own main verb, and never a subordinate clause against its superordinate.
2. They must be **balanced in sense**. If the real relation is causal or consequential, μέν/δέ misdescribes it — subordinate instead, or use οὖν. “The slave was afraid and fled” is a causal chain wearing parallel clothes.
3. μέν and δέ must **immediately follow the specific words being contrasted**: ἐν μὲν τῇ Ἀπολογίᾳ..., ἐν δὲ τῷ Κρίτῳ... If the clauses contain no such focal words, the idiom is impractical — don’t force it.

Related: τε...καί = “both...and,” with τε after the first word of the first member (ὃ τε πρῶτος δοῦλος καὶ ὁ δεύτερος). Bare τε for “and” is poetic; avoid it in prose.

## 2. WORD ORDER — UNITS, OPENERS, THE FOCUS SLOT

Greek word order is free only in the sense that it carries information instead of syntax. The working model:

- A unit opens with a **distinctive opening word** — conjunction, relative, preposition, article — that points forward to its verb; everything between opener and verb belongs to the unit.
- **Postpositives stand second**: δέ, γάρ, οὖν, τε, τοι, ἄν, and the enclitics. This makes them boundary-markers — the clause began with the word *before* the postpositive. They intrude even into otherwise inviolable groups: ἡ δὲ βουλή.
- **The slot directly before the verb is the focus slot**, given to the word on which the unit’s attention falls. Decide what the sentence is *about*, and what it *asserts*; the assertion’s key word wants that slot.
- **Adverbs and negatives stand directly before what they modify**; an adverb modifying the whole sentence goes before the verb (οἶκαδε πάλιν ἤκει, not ἤκει οἶκαδε πάλιν).
- **ἄν moves by clause type**: in subordinate clauses it hugs the opening word (hence the fused forms ἐάν, ὅταν, ἐπειδάν); in main clauses it stays near the verb; if the clause has οὐ, ἄν follows it (οὐκ ἄν εἴη).
- **Attributive vs. predicate position is meaning, not style**: ὁ σοφὸς ἀνὴρ “the wise man” vs. σοφὸς ὁ ἀνὴρ “the man is wise.” πᾶς, αὐτός, and the demonstratives take predicate position: οὗτος ὁ ἀνὴρ, “this man.”
- The **sandwich genitive** is the tight, formal order: ἡ τοῦ Σωκράτους σοφία. Keep appositives adjacent to their noun; if a sentence’s topic needs announcing, front it with a περί-phrase and let the syntax restart cleanly after.

**Drill:** N&H “Position of the Article,” pp. 4–7. **Lookup:** Smyth §§1154 ff. (attributive and predicate position); on the larger questions of order, Dickey’s Unit VI is the clearest modern statement.

### 3. THE ARTICLE

- **Whole classes and abstracts take the article:** οἱ θῆρες “wild beasts,” οἱ ἄνθρωποι “mankind,” ἡ ἀνδρεία “courage” — where English has none.
- **The article makes nouns out of anything:** τὸ ἀληθές “truth,” οἱ πάλαι “the men of old,” and above all τό + infinitive, which nominalizes a whole action — τὸ τοῖς νόμοις πειθαρχεῖν, “obedience to the laws.” Negate the articular infinitive with μή: τὸ μὴ ἀδικεῖν.
- **Article + participle is the standard Greek for an English relative clause:** οἱ λέγοντες “those who speak”; τιμῶμεν τοὺς στρατιώτας τοὺς ὑπὲρ τῆς πόλεως τεθνηκότας, “we honour the soldiers who have died for their city.”
- **Predicate nouns drop the article:** βασιλεὺς ἐγένετο, “he became king.” When both sides are arthrous the statement is a convertible identity; an anarthrous predicate is plain predication — ὁ θεὸς ἀγάπη ἐστὶν predicates love of God without converting.
- **The article as light possessive** where ownership is obvious: τὴν χεῖρα, “his hand.”

Drill: N&H pp. 1–3. Lookup: Smyth §§1118 ff.

### 4. ASPECT BEFORE TENSE

- **Outside the indicative, the tense-stems mark aspect only** — no time. Aorist = the bounded snapshot; present = the running film; perfect = the resulting state. So μὴ ποιήσης “don’t do it” (once, at all) vs. μὴ ποίει “stop doing it”; παύσασθαι “to cease” (the event of stopping). Default to the aorist in infinitives, imperatives, subjunctives, and optatives unless you positively mean a process — the present is the marked choice.
- **In the indicative,** the imperfect covers ongoing, habitual, and attempted past action; ἄν + imperfect is a present counterfactual (“would now be”); ἄν + aorist indicative a past counterfactual (“would have been”).
- **The future participle expresses purpose,** especially with ὥς: ἦλθε λυσόμενος, “he came to ransom.”

Drill: N&H “Tenses in the Indicative,” pp. 10–11; “Tenses in the Participles,” pp. 12–15; “Use of Tenses in the Moods,” pp. 92–93. Lookup: Goodwin, *Moods and Tenses*, for anything the grid won’t settle.

### 5. THE PARTICIPLE ENGINE

Greek subordinates with participles where English reaches for clauses; a good English-to-Greek translation introduces participles the English never hinted at. This is the single biggest step from correct Greek to idiomatic Greek.

- **Circumstantial senses:** time, cause, manner, condition, concession — the bare participle carries any of them, and context decides. Flavor when needed: ἅτε + participle for objective cause, ὥς for alleged cause or purpose, καίπερ for concession.
- **Genitive absolute only when its subject is not a constituent of the main clause.** If the participle’s subject is also the main verb’s subject (or object), use the agreeing participle instead: “having assumed this, he says” is ὑποθέμενος... φησί, nominative, never a genitive absolute.

- For **impersonal expressions** the absolute is accusative: ἐξόν “it being possible,” δέον “it being necessary.”
- **Supplementary participles** complete certain verbs: τυγχάνω (happen to), λανθάνω (escape notice), φθάνω (anticipate), παύομαι (cease: παύσασθαι φιλοσοφῶν), χαίρω, ἄρχομαι, φαίνομαι.
- **φαίνομαι discriminates by complement:** with a participle, “is manifestly” (φαίνεται σοφὸς ὢν — he evidently is); with an infinitive, “seems, but perhaps isn’t” (φαίνεται σοφὸς εἶναι). The choice asserts or withholds your commitment.
- After verbs of **knowing and perceiving**, indirect discourse takes the participle: οἶδα αὐτὸν σοφὸν ὄντα, “I know that he is wise.”

**Drill:** N&H “Genitive Absolute,” pp. 34–37; “Participles,” pp. 122–127; “Impersonal Verbs — Accusative Absolute,” pp. 128–129. **Lookup:** Smyth §§2054 ff. (circumstantial), §2070 (genitive absolute), §§2088 ff. (supplementary).

## 6. MOOD MACHINERY IN INDEPENDENT CLAUSES

- **Potential optative + ἄν:** might, could, would — the mood of the entertained thought. Three stock formulas run whole paragraphs of argumentative prose: δόξειεν ἄν τινι (“it might seem to someone...”), φαίη ἄν τις (“someone might say...” — the objection), ἔροιτο ἄν τις (“someone might ask...” — the question you then answer).
- **Hortatory subjunctive:** πράττωμεν, “let us act.”
- **Deliberative subjunctive:** τί φῶμεν; “what are we to say?”
- **Prohibitions:** μή + present imperative to stop what is under way (μὴ ποίει); μή + aorist subjunctive against beginning (μὴ ποιήσης).
- **Wishes:** εἴθε or εἰ γάρ + optative for the attainable future; a past indicative, or ὥφελον + infinitive, for the unattainable.
- **The verbal adjective in -τέος** = “must be —ed”: οὐ σκεπτέον, “it need not be examined”; the agent goes in the dative.
- **Impersonals take accusative + infinitive:** δεῖ, χρή, ἔξεστι, δοκεῖ. Note that δοκεῖ μοι with an accusative-infinitive clause stays singular no matter the number of the accusative subject — the impersonal parse.

**Drill:** N&H “Commands, Exhortations, Wishes,” pp. 78–79; “Wishes in Present and Past Tense,” pp. 176–177; “Verbal Adjectives,” pp. 130–132; summaries of the subjunctive and optative, pp. 170–175. **Lookup:** Smyth §1824 (potential optative), §1797 (hortatory), §1805 (deliberative), §1840 (prohibitions), §§1814 ff. (wishes), §2149 (verbals in -τέος).

## 7. CONDITIONS — THE GRID

| Type                  | Protasis (if-clause)   | Apodosis               |
|-----------------------|------------------------|------------------------|
| Simple fact           | εἰ + indicative        | indicative             |
| Future more vivid     | ἐάν + subjunctive      | future indicative      |
| Future less vivid     | εἰ + optative          | ἄν + optative          |
| Present general       | ἐάν + subjunctive      | present indicative     |
| Past general          | εἰ + optative          | imperfect              |
| Present contrafactual | εἰ + imperfect         | ἄν + imperfect         |
| Past contrafactual    | εἰ + aorist indicative | ἄν + aorist indicative |

- **ἄν never stands in the protasis** as a modal particle; its reflex there is the fusion ἐάν (= εἰ + ἄν) with the subjunctive.
- The future less vivid — “should...would” — is the argumentative workhorse: εἰ ἀφίοιεν... παράνομος ἄν εἴη, “if they should acquit on that condition, the verdict would be unlawful.”
- **Mixed conditions are deliberate rhetoric**, not errors: εἰ ἀφίοιτε (optative) → πείσομαι (future indicative) — mist in the *if*, granite in the answer.
- **Relative and temporal clauses run the same grid**: ὅς ἄν + subjunctive for the general case (ἃ ἄν κελεύουσιν, “whatever they command”); the optative replaces it after past time.
- **Concession**: εἰ καὶ “even if” (conceding a fact), καὶ εἰ “even supposing” (conceding a hypothesis), καίπερ + participle.

**Drill:** N&H “Conditional Sentences,” pp. 112–121; “Indefinite Construction,” pp. 148–149; “Temporal Clauses,” pp. 150–159; conditionals in oratio obliqua, pp. 178–185. **Lookup:** Smyth’s summary table of conditions, §2297.

## 8. INDIRECT DISCOURSE — THREE SYSTEMS BY HEAD VERB

1. **ὅτι/ὥς + finite verb** — after λέγω, ἀποκρίνομαι, and most verbs of saying. In secondary sequence the verb *may* shift to the **oblique optative**, which marks the content as reported-not-vouched-for; keeping the original mood keeps it vivid. This is a distancing dial, not a rule.
  2. **Accusative + infinitive** — after φημί, νομίζω, οἶομαι, δοκῶ: δοκεῖ μοι συμφωνεῖν τῷ διαλόγῳ, “the two dialogues seem to me to agree.” φημί in particular resists ὅτι in classical prose; give it the infinitive.
  3. **Participle** — after verbs of knowing and perceiving: οἶδα, ὁρῶ, ἀκούω (§5 above).
- **Indirect questions** keep their interrogative, or take εἰ “whether”; alternatives with πότερον... ἢ.
  - **Fears**: μή + subjunctive/optative, “lest it happen”; μή οὐ, “lest it not.” **Effort**: ὅπως + future indicative after verbs of striving.
  - **Quotation mechanics**: φησί is postpositive — insert it after the first word or phrase of the quotation («πείσομαι», φησί, «μᾶλλον τῷ θεῷ ἢ ὑμῖν»); a forward-pointing οἶδε with raised dot introduces a quotation formally (λόγοι οἶδε ...); and when excerpting, trim the source’s own seam-connectives (an opening δέ) without guilt — they joined the original context, not yours.

**Drill:** N&H “Indirect Statement,” pp. 48–55; “Indirect Questions,” pp. 62–67; “Subordinate Clauses in Indirect Speech,” pp. 84–86; “Verbs of Fearing and Precaution,” pp. 98–99; summary of the infinitive, pp. 186–189. **Lookup:** Smyth §§2577 ff. (ὅτι/ὥς statements); §§2591 ff. (oratio obliqua).

## 9. NEGATIVES

- **οὐ negates facts; μή negates everything non-factual:** conditions, purposes, generic statements, infinitives (except in indirect statement), conditional participles, wishes, prohibitions. Compounds follow the split — οὐκέτι/μηκέτι “no longer”: ἐφ’ ὧτε μηκέτι φιλοσοφεῖν, “on condition of no longer philosophizing,” takes μή because the infinitive states a condition, not a fact.
- **Compound negatives reinforce** a preceding simple negative: οὐκ ἦν νόμος οὐδεὶς, “there was no law at all.” A simple negative *after* a compound cancels it.
- **οὐ μή + aorist subjunctive is emphatic denial:** οὐ μὴ παύσωμαι, “I most certainly shall not stop” (Plato, Ap. 29d).
- **Verbs of hindering and denying take a pleonastic μή** (μὴ οὐ when the head verb is itself negated) — untranslated in English.

**Drill:** N&H “Negatives,” pp. 80–81; the summary of οὐ and μή, pp. 162–165; “Verbs of Preventing,” pp. 160–161. **Lookup:** Smyth §§2688 ff.; §2754 (οὐ μὴ).

## 10. PRONOUNS

- **αὐτός** three ways: oblique cases alone = plain “him, her, it”; ὁ αὐτός = “the same”; predicate position = intensive “himself” (αὐτὸς ὁ ἀνὴρ).
- **Reflexives:** ἑαυτοῦ serves within its own clause. The **indirect reflexive** reaches back further — inside reported thought, it points to the person whose thought is being reported: ἀπολύουσιν αὐτόν, “they acquit *him*” — him the thinker, not themselves. (The pattern of Latin *sē*.)
- **Demonstratives divide the field:** ὅδε points forward (“the following”), οὗτος backward (“the aforesaid”), ἐκεῖνος to the distant or famous.
- **Relative attraction:** an accusative relative is attracted into the genitive or dative of its antecedent (ὧν for ἃ). But check the verb’s own case-frame before diagnosing attraction — the “attracted” case is sometimes simply the case the verb governs.
- **Connective relatives open sentences:** διό, ἀνθ’ ὧν, ἐξ ὧν. Watch antecedent scope when a relative stands next to a plural noun it does not modify.

**Drill:** N&H “Pronouns,” pp. 38–43 and 133–138. **Lookup:** Smyth §§1204 ff. (αὐτός), §2522 (attraction).

## 11. FROM ENGLISH TO GREEK — THE ART-FORM RULES

- **Translate the thought, not the words.** English idiom must be dismantled to the fact meant, then rebuilt in Greek idiom: “the king ascended the throne” renders the accession, not the furniture. Greek has its own idioms; a good writer uses them — which is what the phrase-mining workflow in §13 is for.
- **The dictionary discipline.** Never trust an English–Greek dictionary (Woodhouse or any other) as a *source*; treat it as a list of candidates, every one of which must be verified in LSJ before use — the full LSJ, fine print and all, to see the word’s actual constructions and company. Dickey’s version of the warning:

“never use an unfamiliar word simply on the basis of what an English-to-Greek dictionary tells you: always look it up first in LSJ.”

- **Stay inside attested classical prose vocabulary.** Poetic and post-classical words read as flaws in an Attic exercise. (For a deliberately Atticizing-patristic register this becomes a dial rather than a law — but you must know which words move it, which is the same LSJ discipline.)
- **Concretize abstractions.** Most English abstract nouns should become concrete constructions: “Alcibiades’ plot was discovered” → “Alcibiades was discovered plotting” — a participle. Keep only those abstractions Greek itself uses in that sense; when you can’t verify one, go concrete.
- **Build long sentences by subordination.** Greek prose likes extended periods with much subordination; combine short English sentences by subordinating, not by chaining with *καί* — and add participles freely.
- **Modern concepts:** transliterate proper names (the Septuagint and New Testament give the precedent: Ἀβραάμ, Δαβίδ), or periphrase the thing (a submarine: ναῦς ὑφ’ ὕδατι πλέουσα), or transpose to an ancient equivalent only where the context genuinely fits.

## 12. IDIOM TRAPS AND SMALL HARDWARE

- English “is + abstract noun” → prefer a verb; ἔχω + adverb = “be in a state”: καλῶς ἔχει, “it is well.”
- Comparison: ἢ, or the genitive of comparison; ὥς/ὅτι + superlative = “as X as possible” (ὥς τάχιστα).
- μέλλω + future infinitive = “be about to.”
- “On condition that” = ἐφ’ ὧτε + infinitive.
- Result: ὥστε + infinitive for the natural result, + indicative for the actual one.
- Purpose, four ways: ἵνα/ὅπως/ὥς + subjunctive (optative after past time); the future participle; ὅστις + future indicative after expressions of choosing or sending.
- “The same as”: ὁ αὐτὸς καί, or ὁ αὐτός + dative.
- **Enclitic accents**, the cheat-sheet: proparoxytone + enclitic gains a second acute (ἄνθρωποί τινες); paroxytone + disyllabic enclitic leaves the enclitic its accent (εἰκόνες εἰσί); an oxytone keeps its acute before an enclitic (ἐαυτόν τε) where it would take the grave before an ordinary word. Breathing and accent sit on the second vowel of a diphthong (αὐτόν, εἴλετο).

**Drill:** N&H “Prepositions,” pp. 139–142, and the appendices: principal parts pp. 223–229, compound verbs pp. 230–232, prose usages of the prepositions pp. 233–237, accent rules pp. 240–245. **Lookup:** Smyth §§181 ff. (enclitics).

## 13. WORKFLOW — MODELS, MINING, ANALYSIS

1. **Compose from Greek models, not from English.** Before writing, find how a real author says the *kind* of thing you want to say, and take the construction with its case-frame attached. This is what Auden’s *Greek Prose Phrase-Book* is for: idioms drawn from Thucydides, Xenophon, Plato, and Demosthenes, classified by topic — look up the subject, harvest the attested phrase, keep its syntax.
2. **Audit the skeleton first** when revising: every finite verb justifies its mood, every non-indicative form its aspect, every sentence-opening its connective. The connective check is the fastest win per second of any revision pass.

3. **Read the draft aloud.** The ear catches what the eye forgives — especially rhythm, hiatus, and a missing particle.
4. **Analyze what you admire.** Break any striking period from your reading into one-verb units, indent each subordination under its head, and name every unit's opening word and what it points to. Practiced on real authors, this is how the Atticizing writers themselves acquired the register: μίμησις of models, all the way down.
5. **Drill the weak construction.** When a revision keeps flagging the same construction, run the matching N&H exercises (each section's (A) and (B) sets are parallel — one for the first pass, one for revenge), and learn the special vocabularies; ignorance of common words is a constant source of weakness in composition.

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## SOURCES

- M. A. North & A. E. Hillard, *Greek Prose Composition for Schools* (1898). Public domain. Page references above follow the Textkit edition.
- H. W. Auden, *Greek Prose Phrase-Book* (1899). Public domain.
- H. W. Smyth, *Greek Grammar* (1920). Public domain; cited by §.
- W. W. Goodwin, *Syntax of the Moods and Tenses of the Greek Verb* (1890). Public domain.
- J. D. Denniston, *The Greek Particles* (2nd ed. 1954) — in copyright.
- Eleanor Dickey, *An Introduction to the Composition and Analysis of Greek Prose* (Cambridge University Press, 2016) — in copyright; the two brief quotations above (§1, §11) are hers.